Commentary manuscripts

I have just finished collating GA 2817 for Hebrews. It is a commentary MS, and I was impressed with something that I had never focused on before. Such MSS were made to preserve the commentary, not the main Text.

GA 2817, p, XI, is held by the University library in Basel, Switzerland. They have made available very nice digital images, that may be accessed through the INTF. The commentary is written in very neat tiny letters around a blank rectangle in the middle of the inside edge of the page. All the rectangles are the same size. However, rarely does the biblical Text occupy all of the available space, even though the Text is written in letters that are several times larger than those of the commentary. Sometimes the Text scarcely occupies half of the space, and the page break occurs in the middle of a phrase, with no apparent rhyme or reason, since there is plenty of blank space left.

All of that means that the commentary was written first. Then the biblical Text was added, but only what had been commented upon on that page. I would say that the exemplar used for the biblical Text was very nearly perfect Family 35, but the scribe of 2817 made quite a few spelling mistakes as well as minor variants that don't change the meaning. However, it has a few variants that came from the Byzantine tradition outside of Family 35. I did not bother to check the commentary at those spots, but it would not surprise me if the variants were caused by the commentary.

My purpose in writing this short note is to say this: commentary MSS were not prepared in order to preserve the biblical Text, so we should not expect them to be especially fine copies of that Text.